

Source Silence Investigation Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	source-silence-investigation

Big idea: Historical knowledge depends not only on surviving sources, but also on recognizing what did not survive.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Packet: official school notice, newspaper paragraph, teacher diary, but no student voices. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Source Silence Investigation Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Packet: merchant account, travel diary, law code, but no record from workers affected by the policy. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Source Silence Investigation Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Packet: merchant account, travel diary, law code, but no record from workers affected by the policy. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Historical knowledge depends not only on surviving sources, but also on recognizing what did not survive.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Source Silence Investigation Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	How can we know responsibly when evidence is missing?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Packet: official school notice, newspaper paragraph, teacher diary, but no student voices.
- Packet: merchant account, travel diary, law code, but no record from workers affected by the policy.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Activity Steps

1. Give groups a short source packet about one event.
2. Students list whose voices, records, or perspectives are present.
3. Groups infer which voices may be missing and why.
4. Students revise one conclusion to include uncertainty from source silence.
5. Debrief how historians responsibly reason from incomplete archives.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: How can we know responsibly when evidence is missing?
- Is absence of evidence evidence of absence?
- How do preservation and power shape historical knowledge?

Knowledge Questions

- How can we know responsibly when evidence is missing?
- How do archives shape historical knowledge?
- What does source silence reveal about power?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a source packet where one group's voice is missing. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...